



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Saint Benedict Catholic School

School Website: <http://saintbenedictschool.org>

January 7, 2026

Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

SCL MEMBER

Any school that belongs to the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because SCL requires adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

Saint Benedict Catholic School (Richmond, VA 23221) presents a robust, self-conscious classical-Catholic program that aligns strongly with the core six-element classical rubric. Public-facing materials identify a Catholic, classical approach from JK through 8th grade, with explicit emphasis on truth, beauty, and goodness, Latin instruction, memorization and recitation, and engagement with great works. The school also foregrounds liturgical life, daily prayer, Mass, and a theology-infused formation, all central to a trans-religious, metaphysical frame. Pedagogical practice exhibits a balance of contemplative elements (memory work, liturgical rhythm, wonder) and discussion-based elements (seminars and "Seminar" in secondary grades), and the faculty are depicted as active mentors within a small, family-like culture. Parent partnerships are reinforced via a vibrant Parent Hub, PTO, and frequent opportunities for engagement. Taken together, the site-scaffolded evidence supports a CLASSICAL evaluation across all six categories, with especially strong signals in Religious and Metaphysical Foundations, Curriculum, Pedagogy, and Parents & Community.

This assessment draws on two sources: - The school's own public materials (cited below) showing Catholic identity, classical content, and a Great-Books-influenced approach (e.g., The Great Works, Latin in Grade 1, memorization, and liturgical life). - The knowledge-base rubric for classical education (Six Essential Elements of a Classical School, including the Positive Keyword indicators such as truth/goodness/beauty, theology, liturgy, Great Books, Trivium, Scholé, and the formation-focused orientation) which provides the taxonomy used to score and justify each category.

Overall, the aggregate rating is CLASSICAL.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials position Catholic identity at the core of education: "Faithfully Catholic, we educate children in the Classical tradition" and "Faith is the foundation of everything we do," with Mass and daily prayer foregrounded in school life. - The campus emphasizes truth, beauty, and goodness, with Christ at the center of learning; the Academics page explicitly anchors knowledge in truth, beauty, and goodness. - Liturgical life and communal prayer are highlighted (e.g., School Mass; liturgical year; parish connection).

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keyword indicators present: truth, goodness, beauty; virtue; theology; liturgy; Mass; prayer; sacred traditions; imago Dei; divine order; sacred music; reverence; wonder. These align with the Six Elements lexicon's Positive Keywords for this category. See The Good Teacher materials and Six Elements lexicon for corroboration. - Negative signals (e.g., secular relativism, value-neutral ethics) are not evidenced in the public materials.

Why this rating - The school's public materials consistently tie formation to a theologically grounded, liturgically integrated framework. The explicit Catholic theology, sacramental life, and the claim that education is rooted in a Christian metaphysical order meet the Positive Keyword indicators for Transcendental Moral Realism, Grounded Theology, and Liturgical/Communal Practices, yielding a CLASSICAL assessment for this category. The presence of liturgical life and theology-infused formation is clear and ongoing.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Mission statements emphasize formation of virtue and wisdom rather than mere information; the aim is human flourishing and moral formation within a Catholic framework (e.g., "Faithfully Catholic, we educate children... in the Classical tradition"; "formation and virtue" language throughout). - The school presents a vision of education as "formation" toward truth, goodness, and beauty, with human excellence and moral imagination implied in the Saint Benedict narrative.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keyword indicators present: formation, virtue, human flourishing, telos, liberal education, who we are (Catholic formation), great conversation, virtue ethics. These map to the lexicon's indicators for the purpose and goal category. - No evidence of value-neutral, job-focused, or solely workforce-oriented language in the public materials.

Why this rating - The materials consistently frame education as formation rather than information—formations of character, faith, and intellect are foregrounded. The alignment with virtue, wisdom, and classical telos signals CLASSICAL orientation for this category.

Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Explicit reference to a classical curriculum with Latin beginning in Grade 1, memorization/recitation, The Great Works, and integrated (interconnected) subject matter (e.g., "A Classical Approach," "The Great Works," Latin in Grade 1, and integrated learning). - Curriculum overview highlights foundational liberal-arts elements (grammar, logic, rhetoric) via the classical model; there is explicit emphasis on classical readings and Great Works to shape character and intellect. - The school markets itself as "Classically Formed in Mind & Spirit" with emphasis on Latin, classical literature, and a unified curriculum.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: Latin, Great Works, memorization/recitation, grammar/logic/rhetoric (Trivium), integration of subjects, great books, reading/writing/thinking well, classical literature, sacred tradition, and Western heritage. These align with the Six Elements lexicon's curricular indicators. - Negative keywords (e.g., project-based or purely STEM-first frames) are not evident in the public materials.

Why this rating - Saint Benedict's materials consistently present a curricular architecture anchored in the seven liberal arts framework (beginning with Latin, grammar, logic, rhetoric, and interlocking with history, literature, and theology). The explicit emphasis on The Great Works and integrated learning substantiates a CLASSICAL rating for Curriculum.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Memory-based pedagogy is foregrounded: "Memorization & Recitation" as a hallmarks of their classical approach, with Scripture, prayers, poetry, and math facts committed to memory. - Lower-level pedagogy includes singing/chanting with regular review to deepen memory and delight, indicating a contemplative, rest-filled pedagogical approach (Schol  -like). The Good Teacher materials emphasize chanting, memory work, and a song-led lower school. - Upper-level pedagogy includes Socratic-style elements, seminars, and rhetoric/memory work (eighth-grade seminar; public-speaking opportunities). The Leadership and Curriculum materials reference "seminars" and rhetoric in the upper grades, indicating a shift toward dialogic, rhetorical instruction. - The curriculum's emphasis on "reading, writing & thinking well" and integrated learning also points to a pedagogy that blends contemplative, memory-based elements with higher-order discussion and analysis.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: memorization/recitation, contemplative learning, scholé, wonder, Socratic dialogue/seminars, rhetoric, oratory, debate, memory work, liturgical memory, and disciplined dialogue. These match the lexicon's Pedagogy indicators for a classical approach. - Negative signals (e.g., experiential-only or project-based pedagogy as the sole method) are not evidenced; the public materials show a balanced mix—memory work and Socratic discussion with abstract reasoning.

Why this rating - The combination of memory-based learning (Scholé-style pace), recitation, Great-Works readings, Latin, and the explicit use of seminars and rhetoric in upper grades aligns with CLASSICAL Pedagogy indicators. The presence of lower-school chant/memory and upper-school seminar/rhetoric demonstrates a layered, age-appropriate classical pedagogy.

Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Leadership materials identify the principal, pastor, and dean of faculty, with explicit ties to classical formation (e.g., the principal's background in Great Books and classical studies; a long-tenured, family-like staff). The leadership content frames teachers as mentors with a strong mission, and the faculty pages point to a cohesive team with a shared approach. - The site references a community of teachers who model virtue and knowledge, with the principal explicitly promoting classical education and teacher leadership. The "Faculty & Staff" page (linked from About) demonstrates the presence of a defined staff structure and a living-curriculum ethos. - The school emphasizes a small-class, close-knit community where teachers know students well and partner with families, which can be read as a living-curriculum approach (teachers as mentors and exemplars).

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: model teachers and mentors; living curriculum (as an institutional expectation in classical pedagogy); portrait of a teacher; collegiality among faculty; mentorship; etc., as supported by the classical lexicon. The Saint Benedict materials emphasize teacher-student partnerships, a family-like culture, and teacher leadership in the classical tradition. - No explicit negative signals about faculty (e.g., a strictly non-classical "teacher as technician" portrayal).

Why this rating - The public materials depict faculty as central figures in the student formation process, with long-tenured teachers and a leadership team that foregrounds classical formation, virtue modeling, and mentorship. This aligns with CLASSICAL indicators for Faculty.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school emphasizes a strong partnership with families—parents are co-educators, and there are explicit structures (Parent Hub, PTO, parent service hours, etc.). The site presents multiple channels for parental involvement and education about classical education (book studies, gatherings). - The Parent Hub and PTO links signal ongoing parental engagement and collaborative governance in the school's community life. The public materials also indicate open access for parent visits and a community-centric environment. - The school's mission statement and philosophy frame education as a family-partnered enterprise rooted in faith and classical formation. This is reinforced by the Catholic identity not being a mere subject, but the atmosphere of the school.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with families, co-educators, parental engagement, home-school collaboration, family formation, parent formation, open campus, parent events, and family-centered community. These align with the Six Elements lexicon for Parents & Community. - Negative keywords (e.g., "customer" mentality or minimal parent involvement) are not evidenced.

Why this rating - The school demonstrates robust family engagement and parental partnership across multiple channels (PTO, Parent Hub, summer reading, service hours). The public materials show an intentional, ongoing effort to educate and involve parents as co-educators in the classical project. This meets CLASSICAL indicators for Parents & Community.

Aggregate Ranking - All six categories: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary — Final Assessment - Overall classification: CLASSICAL - Rationale: Saint Benedict Catholic School (Richmond, VA) presents a coherent Catholic-classical program across religious foundations, formation goals, curriculum, pedagogy, faculty, and parent/community engagement. The Great Works, Latin in Grade 1, memorization/recitation, liturgical life, and a strong sense of formation align with canonical classical indicators. The presence of a small, tight-knit community, with sustained teacher leadership and active parental partnership, reinforces the classical orientation. The school's high degree of alignment across the six categories supports a CLASSICAL designation.

What Would Move the Needle - Not applicable here, as no SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL signals are evident across the six categories. (If any category showed tentative alignment, needle-moving suggestions would be provided; none are required given the current evidence.)

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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